



RAHUL SHARMA, 17

OBC RANK 398

His father, a computer operator, sold his typewriters to support his son's education and Rahul made him proud by cracking the IIT in the first attempt itself. "I fixed study targets and followed them assiduously," he says proudly.

and learn some lessons. These boys are living examples of what a sound family value system can produce," adds Jha.

Eighteen-year-old Alok Kumar would always hear a voice in his head that told him to rescue his family from poverty. The voice was loud and prominent and Alok worked for hours while preparing for the IIT, sometimes all night while his mother sat and watched, often cooling him with a palm-frond fan. Father Anil Kumar is a small-time lawyer who earns only Rs 3,500-Rs 4,000 a month. Elder brother Aakash, who suffers from a muscular disorder, cannot walk without help. "My father often had to borrow money to meet my study expenditure.

Sometimes we had no money to buy medicines for my brother. I knew I could help only by studying," he says. This general category student is ranked 6,636 in the overall merit list.

The crucial role of the mother also gets magnified in the case of 17-year-old Vishwaraj Anand, who is ranked 1,305 in the IIT merit list for the OBCs. Anand's family of six stays in the hall of their flat, as they have rented out all the three bedrooms for Rs 3,000 a month. His father is unemployed and chronically sick, and his mother, Pushpa Sinha, is a homemaker. The hall obviously is too small for Vishwaraj, his parents and three sisters. But Vishwaraj had a solution. He started studying at night in the kitchen where the gas cylinder was his bookshelf and quarrelling cockroaches his companions. "How he concentrates, how he focuses his mind, I really don't know," his mother says. But Vishwaraj's mother indeed does because she is also the one who sacrificed everything, including her sleep, for her boy's success. She always found her son drenched in sweat and at times solving a mathematics problem mentally. It was usual for the mother-son duo to talk at 3 a.m., each giving the other a pep talk, a word of encouragement.

Growing up in a village in Bihar's Rohtas district and studying by a kerosene lamp, life was not easy for 17-year-old Sushant Gaurav. When he moved to Patna to prepare for the JEE exam, he carried bags of food supplies from home, as he couldn't afford to buy them in town. In Patna, Sushant joined five other students from his district to rent a two-room flat. Though there were few distractions, as everyone there was preparing for the IIT entrance, Sushant was always short of money. His farmer father, Suresh Prasad, who made it through Class XII, earns Rs 50,000 a year. But he never asked his son to help him in the farm. Sushant knew all this. So he never used auto rickshaws while commuting to his coaching class, which was a 5-km bicycle ride. His legs would often ache but his focus was elsewhere. He was aptly rewarded with rank 1,031 in the OBC category.

Similarly, 18-year-old Nagendra Ram from Chhapra district stayed in a student lodge at Patna, sharing a small room with his brother. At the lodge, a tape recorder would be blaring in the next room, other boys



SATISH KUMAR, 17

OBC RANK 912

"I never thought about what I did not have. I knew I was better than many others," says Satish. Staying in a two-room house with his widowed mother, an elder brother and his sister's infant daughter, he used to study on his mother's sewing machine table as the family could not afford a study table.

